



▲ In January 2007, the iconic 1947-built WP 7200, or *Azad*, was steamed up for a 60 km run in New Delhi as part of the “Rail Heritage Month”.

## **Better than steam**

Author and railwayman MA Rao noted that the growing expense of coal and increasing demand for efficiency meant that electric and diesel traction were given preference. Steam faced several challenges, which included low speed, slow acceleration, and time lost on watering, coaling, maintenance, and turning the locomotive after it reached its destination. All this cut into its usage time – steam locomotives could run for about 12 hours a day while the diesel or electric ones could be used for up to 21 hours.